

STUDY GUIDE UNHRC



Agenda 1 : Addressing Implications of
the Digital Age on Linguistic Minorities

Agenda 2 : Assessing the Role of
Media in Conflict Zones





Letter from R&D

Dear Delegates,

The Department of Research & Development of MUNSociety MPSTME welcomes you to the 11th edition of Mumbai MUN! Our department upholds a proud tradition of facilitating meaningful discourse on national and international matters, encompassing both historical events and current issues.

We are primarily tasked with formulating agendas and preparing comprehensive study guides. We have created detailed and engaging guides aimed at providing valuable resources for all delegates.

This year's theme, "Redefine the Norm," challenges us to think beyond conventional solutions and embrace innovative approaches to global challenges. In a rapidly evolving world, traditional methods often fall short of addressing contemporary issues. We believe that transformative change requires the courage to question established practices and the creativity to envision alternative pathways.

With this theme in mind, we have thoroughly picked agendas and committees that demand fresh perspectives, challenge conventional thought, and encourage innovative approaches to problem-solving. In this study guide, you will find well-researched background information to help you prepare for your committee sessions.

We, as facilitators, aim to provide you with the intellectual arsenal to combat any challenges that you might face and make the most of your Mumbai MUN experience.

We look forward to your active participation and contributions during Mumbai MUN and are confident that, together, we can make this conference a memorable and enriching experience for all.

Best wishes,

Department of Research & Development,
MUNSociety MPSTME.



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Note: The QARMAs will be released pre-conference, post consultation with the Executive Board.

Agenda 1: Addressing Implications of the Digital Age on Linguistic Minorities

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

Mandate

The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) is dedicated to advancing and safeguarding human rights globally. It was established by the General Assembly in 2006 to serve as the primary intergovernmental body within the United Nations. It provides a platform for UN officials, government representatives and civil society members to address challenges related to the protection of human rights.¹

The key functions of UNHRC include:

- Adopts resolutions or decisions during regular sessions that reflect the stance of the internal community on various matters of concern. This, in turn, prompts the government to take significant measures to counter the issues;
- Convening special sessions to address the pressing human rights issues, with 36 such meetings held so far;
- Conducts Universal Periodic Review to review the human right practices of all UN members;
- Appoints the Special Procedures, independent human rights experts who serve as the eyes and ears of the Council by monitoring situations in specific countries or by looking at specific themes; and
- Authorises commissions of inquiry and fact-finding missions, which are tasked

with gathering substantial evidence on war crimes and crimes against humanity.

BACKGROUND

In today's multipolar and globalised world, the ability to use and engage with digital platforms is heavily influenced by the dominance of English and other dominant languages. However, whilst aiming for global connectivity, it is easy to forget the importance of preserving local diversity and culture. While studying linguistic minorities it is important to note that they are a result of years of discrimination, neglect, and failure to preserve culture and heritage languages.

A few terminologies you must be familiar with before addressing the agenda at hand include but are not limited to the digital divide, language technologies, linguistic minorities, and heritage language. Firstly, the digital divide refers to the gap between groups that have access to modern technology and digital platforms and those that do not. This divide keeps increasing when efforts are not directed toward resources being translated into minority languages, making it difficult for linguistic minorities to access digital spaces. We eventually encounter a paradox: without representation on digital platforms, there is limited access to translated resources; yet without resources, there can be no significant presence or development for these communities online.

Another key term is language technologies, which are tools designed to analyse and process speech, language, and translations through software applications. These technologies are important for creating inclusive presence on digital platforms, and for enabling the cultural

¹Human Rights Council. (n.d.). *About the council*. OHCHR. <https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/hrc/about-council#:~:text=The%20Human%20Rights%20Council%20is%20the%20main%20intergovernmental%20body%20within,human%20rights%20around%20the%20globe.>

integration of linguistic minorities into the digital world. In the digital age, the value of a language is closely linked to its presence on digital platforms and in language technologies. Intangible cultural heritage which includes languages and oral histories must be treated with equal importance to ensure they are represented tangibly in the digital sphere. Without a digital presence, these cultural elements are at risk of erosion in an increasingly interconnected world.

HISTORY

The recognition of language preservation as a way of safeguarding cultural identity has been long established, but due to the influence of colonialism and the lack of concerted efforts, there was less to no progress for many years towards this cause. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948) and the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (1966) laid down the foundations for linguistic rights, stating that minorities had the right to enjoy and practise their religion and language. However, despite these provisions, the dominance of certain global languages continued.

By the 1980s, the era of the internet brought new possibilities, but it also increased existing disparities. Access to digital resources was largely concentrated in developed countries, which hosted English-dominated content, leaving non-English-speaking populations marginalised. In 1992, in response to increasing concerns about minority rights, the UN Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious, and Linguistic Minorities (UNDRPN) was passed to protect and promote the identity of linguistic minorities.

In the early 2000s, digital platforms like Google Translate helped in reducing the language gap by introducing translation tools that allowed non-

English speakers to communicate online. However, these technologies often produced inaccurate translations for lesser-spoken languages compared to dominant languages like English. The UN Special Rapporteur on Minority Issues highlighted these challenges in reports, emphasising the risk of digital divides worsening without policy intervention.



UN Special Rapporteur Highlights Need for New UN convention for Minority Rights

Source: European Language Equality Network

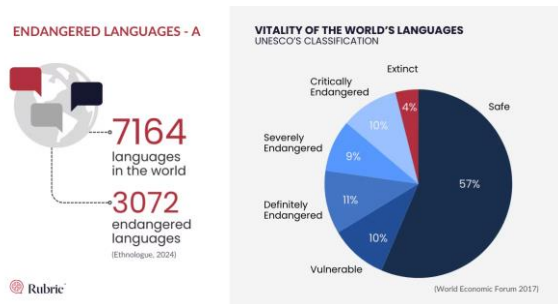
Efforts to address the gap culminated in the International Year of Indigenous Languages (2019), which brought attention to the struggles of indigenous communities and their languages in the digital world. However, the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 created a new era for increasing these disparities even further. As education and resources moved online, linguistic minorities struggled to access materials that were not available in their native languages. The pandemic served as an eye-opener for urgent action in making digital spaces more inclusive.

In 2022, the UN Global Action Plan for Digital Inclusion was launched, aiming to bridge the digital divide by improving digital literacy and representation for linguistic minorities. This plan focused on revising digital policies to be more inclusive and representative of the world's linguistic diversity.

Today, approximately 40% of the world's 7,000 languages² are at risk of extinction, a trend that

²UNESCO. (n.d.). *Multilingual education: A bet to preserve indigenous languages and justice*. UNESCO.
<https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/multilingual-education-bet-preserve-indigenous-languages-and->

stems from both colonial legacies and modern national policies. The overlap between language and the erosion of cultural identity is a critical issue, one that requires both historical understanding and forward-thinking solutions to combat the challenges that linguistic minorities face in the digital age.



Endangered languages

Source: Rubric

CAUSES

The deep-rooted challenges faced by linguistic minorities can be understood through two distinct historical phases: the colonial phase and the post-colonial phase. While it may seem easy to blame colonial history for the current gaps in the accessibility of heritage languages, it is equally essential to understand how post-colonial developments have failed to combat these challenges or made them far more severe.

Colonial Phase

One of the most effective tools for political control and cultural dominance employed by colonisers was the imposition of their language as the primary mode of communication. During the early colonial period, the groundwork for the marginalisation of indigenous and local languages was firmly established. Languages imposed by colonisers, like French in West Africa, were not only used for governance but also introduced as the medium of instruction in educational institutions. In Africa, countries like

Senegal and Côte d'Ivoire still primarily use French as their official language, a colonial legacy that continues to marginalise local languages. This reduced the utility of local languages, which were not aligned with colonial interests. As a result, native languages in these regions lost their significance.

Colonial education systems often abandoned rich texts composed in native languages, with some being discarded or misrepresented in translations. In many instances, students who spoke in indigenous languages were punished, which fueled a sense of inferiority toward their linguistic heritage.

Colonisers also divided societies along various lines, including language, creating a hierarchy that placed those fluent in the colonial language above those who were not. Opportunities for social and economic mobility were largely available only to those who met the language requirements. This deepened the marginalisation of indigenous language speakers and further fragmented communities. The lack of efforts to protect heritage languages, combined with these divisions, hindered the unity of indigenous populations in resisting colonial dominance.

Post-Colonial Phase

It is interesting to observe that even post-independence, nations continued to oppress indigenous languages under a new cause called national unity. After independence, many newly formed nations struggled to create a unified national identity, particularly in the wake of the divide-and-rule policies left behind by colonisers. In their quest for unity, some nations chose a single indigenous or colonial language as the national language, inadvertently marginalising linguistic minorities. The lack of deliberate

efforts to preserve minority languages compounded the existing inequalities.

Moreover, the education systems established during colonial rule remained in place post-independence, gaining even more importance with the rise of globalisation and the digital age. Languages taught under colonial rule continued to dominate the educational sphere, and linguistic minorities were often left behind due to slow reforms in the education system. Students from minority language backgrounds struggled to achieve academic and professional success, in light of the language barriers.

Mass media further reinforced the dominance of major languages. Countries, seeking to participate in a globalised world order, prioritised international languages, and digital media followed these trends. As a result, minority languages were sidelined, and their value diminished in the face of increasing digital influence.

Technological advancements also disproportionately benefited speakers of major languages. Even today, digital platforms and technological resources are predominantly available in English and other major languages, making it difficult for marginalised communities to represent their perspectives or access the same opportunities. The primary reason for this gap is the lack of investment in developing technological resources that promote linguistic diversity, creating additional barriers for minority language speakers.

Access to information, education, and economic opportunities has remained restricted for linguistic minorities even in the post-colonial phase, continuing their marginalisation.

The key difference between the suppression of minority languages during the colonial era and the post-colonial phase lies in the nature of the suppression. In the colonial period, suppression was direct and tied to the hierarchical control

imposed by colonisers. In the post-colonial period, the marginalisation of minority languages has often been an unintended consequence of nation-building efforts and economic development strategies. Unfortunately, digital platforms today continue to reflect these historical inequalities, as language barriers still prevent equitable representation for linguistic minorities.

EFFECTS

The effects of the digital age on linguistic minorities can be studied across three broad levels—local, national, and international. When forming policies for linguistic minorities, governments and institutions delegates should consider their impact at all these levels to create effective and inclusive strategies.

Local Level

At the grassroots level, the major stakeholders are the individuals engaging directly with digital platforms. Unfortunately, many of these platforms lack adequate support for local languages, which creates a linguistic barrier for minority language speakers. As digital media becomes more prevalent, it fosters a sense of dominance of major languages, as most of the content is primarily available in a language that minority speakers may not understand. This lack of representation in digital spaces contributes to feelings of exclusion and marginalisation.

However, community initiatives are emerging at the local level to support linguistic minorities, often in the form of digital infrastructure projects aimed at increasing local language visibility online. These efforts have led to the slow rise of local content creators and social media pages that share content in local languages. Native content and linguistic diversity have been noted as upcoming trends in the digital space. Such initiatives can help preserve cultural heritage, but they also highlight the growing generational gap. Younger generations, who are more adept at

using digital platforms, often adopt mainstream languages for digital communication, which may lead to a decline in the perceived importance of their heritage languages.

National Level

At the national level, the lack of sufficient budget and economic policies dedicated to empowering local languages presents a significant challenge. National language policies tend to prioritise proficiency in dominant or international languages, which creates barriers for linguistic minorities seeking employment or access to essential services. Digital inclusion is another area where linguistic minorities face inequities, as educational materials and policy documents are rarely translated into native languages.

The representation of linguistic minorities in governmental organisations and decision-making bodies is often lacking, further undermining efforts to promote inclusive national policies. In some countries, governments may use digital surveillance to monitor and suppress minority groups, targeting them based on the languages they speak. This adds another layer of marginalisation, as linguistic minorities may refrain from expressing themselves freely online, fearing persecution or identification by the authorities.

International Level

At the international level, the challenges faced by linguistic minorities intersect with various human rights issues, particularly those related to cultural identity and the right to preserve one's language. Stateless minorities, in particular, often struggle to access digital spaces due to a lack of representation in global platforms, including essential services like banking and

digital identification. These individuals are often forced to integrate into the dominant language of their host country, further eroding their linguistic heritage.

There is increasing recognition within the international community of the need to create diverse online archives and digital repositories for endangered languages. However, the creation of digital libraries and archives is both costly and technically demanding, limiting the speed and scope of these efforts. As countries and businesses increasingly engage in globalised activities, the dominance of international languages in digital communication continues to grow, pushing regional languages further to the margins.

PAST LAWS

UN Declaration on Rights of Persons

The UN Declaration on the Rights of Persons Belonging to National or Ethnic, Religious, and Linguistic Minorities (1992)³ forms a foundational framework for linguistic rights. This declaration obliges member states to protect the linguistic identity of minorities and ensure that they have the freedom to use, maintain, and develop their language. In the context of the digital age, this means governments must actively support the development of digital resources in minority languages. The declaration implies that digital platforms should serve as spaces for preserving linguistic and cultural identities, rather than marginalising minority groups.

The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights

³OHCHR. (n.d.). *Declaration on the rights of persons belonging to national or ethnic, religious and linguistic minorities*.
<https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/declaration-rights-persons-belonging-national-or-ethnic>

The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR)⁴, adopted in 1966, touches on the importance of upholding linguistic diversity, even in the context of digital communication. Article 27 of the ICCPR specifically recognizes the rights of linguistic minorities to enjoy their culture, practise their religion, and use their language. Although the treaty predates the digital age, its principles remain highly relevant today. The ICCPR advocates for equal access to information across digital platforms, underscoring the necessity for digital services and online tools to be accessible in multiple languages, thus ensuring that linguistic minorities are not left behind in the information age.

Charter on the Preservation of Digital Heritage

In 2003, UNESCO issued a Charter on the Preservation of Digital Heritage⁵, which calls for the protection of cultural and linguistic content online. This charter recognizes that the internet and other digital platforms have become repositories of knowledge and identity and that the preservation of linguistic diversity is essential. The charter encourages the creation of online archives and digital libraries to store linguistic and cultural content, ensuring that minority languages are not erased from the digital landscape.

2018 European Parliament Resolution

A 2018 European Parliament Resolution⁶ also addresses the impact of the digital transition on linguistic minorities. This resolution emphasises the need for economic funding to support the

development of inclusive technologies, particularly in the fields of artificial intelligence (AI) and deep learning. The goal is to ensure that minority languages are supported by these advanced technologies. The resolution underscores the importance of public investment in making digital tools accessible to speakers of minority languages, promoting inclusivity in an increasingly globalised and digital world.

International Organisations

Several international organisations work to protect linguistic rights in the digital age. UNESCO continues to promote programs that emphasise the need for linguistic diversity online, encouraging the creation of digital archives for endangered languages and supporting the development of educational tools in multiple languages. The European Union (EU) also supports multilingualism through various policies that ensure multiple languages are represented in digital spaces. Additionally, the World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) focuses on the protection of cultural and linguistic expressions in digital platforms, ensuring that the intellectual property rights of indigenous and minority language speakers are upheld. The Indigenous Languages Digital Archive (ILDA) works to digitise endangered languages, creating a growing repository of linguistic heritage accessible to global communities. Lastly, the Endangered Languages Project is dedicated to the documentation and preservation of endangered languages using digital tools, ensuring that these languages are passed down to future generations.

⁴ International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights | Ohchr. (n.d.). <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights>

⁵ *Charter on the Preservation of the Digital Heritage*. (n.d.). UNESCO Digital Library. Retrieved October 27, 2024, from <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000179529>

⁶ *2018 European Parliament Resolution*. (n.d.). EUR-Lex. Retrieved October 27, 2024, from <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX%3A52018IP0032>

CASE STUDY

Maori Language in New Zealand

The revitalization of the Māori language in New Zealand is a powerful example of how a community, with government support, can successfully promote and preserve a native language. This revitalization can be examined through various efforts undertaken at both the grassroots and institutional levels.

A significant milestone in this movement was the Māori Language Act of 1987, which officially recognized Māori as the official language of New Zealand. This legislative step laid the foundation for integrating the language into the country's legal, educational, and governmental systems. With official recognition came an increase in resources and efforts to ensure the language continued to thrive in both public and private spheres. The Act helped cement the importance of Māori in New Zealand's identity and culture, contributing to its resurgence across multiple aspects of society.

Maori Language Week⁷ has become a nationwide event, aimed at encouraging all citizens of New Zealand to use Māori in daily life. This annual celebration brings attention to the language by creating a strong connection with the public, using various digital platforms such as media campaigns, community events, and public participation to raise awareness. During this week, digital tools like the apps Kupu and Te Aka have been instrumental in providing easy access to Māori translations and encouraging language learning. Kupu allows users to take photos and receive Māori translations of the objects in the image, while Te Aka is a comprehensive Māori-

English dictionary. This use of digital technology has greatly boosted short-term awareness and engagement with the language. Major stakeholders such as tech giants Google and Microsoft have also integrated Māori into their systems, contributing to a global recognition of the language and creating a ripple effect beyond New Zealand.

For long-term language revitalization, New Zealand took several important steps early on. One such initiative was the creation of Kura Kaupapa Māori, schools that provide education entirely in Māori. These schools play a pivotal role in fostering future generations of fluent Māori speakers and building a strong sense of cultural identity. In addition to formal education, community efforts have focused on encouraging household learning, with programs that promote the use of Māori at home.

Since 2018, the proportion of people able to speak more than a few words or phrases of te reo Māori has risen from 24 per cent to 30 per cent. This follows a previous, smaller, rise between 2016 and 2018⁸. It serves as a great example of how national initiatives can still preserve heritage languages in today's digital age.

Ainu Language in Japan

The Ainu people, an indigenous group from Hokkaido in northern Japan, have faced significant cultural and linguistic pressures since Japan annexed their territory in the 19th century. Following annexation, the Japanese government pursued policies that aimed to assimilate the Ainu into Japanese society, which resulted in the suppression of the Ainu language. Disguised under the guise of "protecting" and "integrating"

⁷Māori language week - Te Taura Whiri i Te Reo Māori. (n.d.). <https://en.tetaurawhiri.govt.nz/te-wiki>

⁸Te Reo Māori proficiency and support continues to grow: Stats NZ. Te reo Māori proficiency and support continues to grow | Stats NZ. (n.d.). <https://www.stats.govt.nz/news/te-reo-maori-proficiency-and-support-continues-to-grow/>

the Ainu, these policies mandated Japanese-language education, leaving little space for the Ainu to preserve their cultural and linguistic heritage. This approach contributed to the marginalisation of the Ainu, reducing minority representation and forcing them to adopt Japanese cultural norms.

A lack of resources translated into Ainu, coupled with the Japanese government's historical lack of emphasis on preserving the language, meant that the internet provided limited support for language revitalization efforts. By the 1990s, however, as the critically endangered status of the Ainu language became clear, the Japanese government began taking steps to preserve and promote Ainu culture. Various digital and community initiatives were introduced to digitise Ainu oral histories, traditional songs, and other cultural artefacts yet the UNESCO Atlas of the World's Languages in Danger listed Ainu as critically endangered, with fewer than 100 speakers remaining in 2009.

The Foundation for Research and Promotion of Ainu Culture (FRPAC)⁹ was one of the key initiatives to promote the preservation and revitalization of the Ainu language and culture. The foundation has since supported projects to document and digitise the Ainu language, including the creation of dictionaries and archives. This has enabled Ainu oral traditions, stories, and cultural practices to be preserved in digital formats. Further, they provide training instructors, language classes, intercultural study exchange programs and support teaching materials in Ainu Language.

The revival of the Ainu language has faced ongoing challenges, such as a lack of institutional

support and limited resources for teaching the language. However, efforts to digitise the language and promote cultural pride among younger generations have shown promising signs, particularly through cultural festivals and online platforms that celebrate Ainu heritage.

In 2019, Japan passed a law officially recognizing the Ainu as an indigenous people, a step forward in promoting their cultural and linguistic rights, but effective implementation remains a challenge.



Distinctive characteristics of Ainu Language
Source: Japan House

CONCLUSION

Technology and digital media have provided a vital impetus to bringing ideas together however it must not exclude or override the importance of regional and local languages for society. As we enter into the age of increased digital media usage, we must improve upon accessibility of digital resources for all. Educational resources and economic opportunities must be made more inclusive for those who continue to take pride in their heritage language while ensuring their digital literacy in the digital age. Initiatives at all levels must be initiated with justifiable funding and human resources to ensure they provide quality efforts and sustained outputs.

⁹The Foundation for Ainu Culture. Retrieved October 28, 2024, from <https://www.ff-ainu.or.jp/web/english/>

Agenda 2: Assessing the Role of Media in Conflict Zones

INTRODUCTION

Defined broadly, conflict zones are areas experiencing ongoing armed conflicts or tensions in peace and stability. In times of conflict and crisis, the media becomes the sole voice of the people and the source from which the international community looks for information. Media includes all forms of communication channels including newspapers, radio, television and new digital platforms of social media. International media defines what is relevant from different happenings of the world and the bodies are then dependent on these definitions for providing aid or help. The reality is that if no one knows what is going on, no one can help. Case studies show that with human rights violations, the scale and accuracy of coverage that they receive have an important impact on the scale of international outrage and assistance that follows, and also on the effectiveness of that assistance.

On the downside is the misuse of media for spreading misinformation, inciting violence and becoming an accomplice for ethnic unrest and genocides. It is essential to understand the differences between propaganda, disinformation and misinformation. Propaganda is the art of shaping a biased public opinion, disinformation is purposely spreading false information and misinformation is the spread of incorrect information unintendedly.

International bodies like the United Nations and NGOs like Reporters Without Borders have set out guidelines for creating an ecosystem of unbiased and safe reporting; however, in the chaos of a conflict zone, the goal of media channels are influenced by external motives. In conflict zones, the duty of conflict-sensitive reporting falls upon two kinds of media-

state-controlled media and independent media. Conflict-sensitive reporting is one of the methods

of journalism that considers the impact of reporting to avoid tensions from escalation. In this agenda, we aim to understand the role of media in conflict zones and how it can be coordinated for the betterment of various stakeholders involved.

HISTORY

Media has been an integral part of writing history and being a part of history. In World War II, the media was a key player in reporting the realities of war to the public. It was misused for spreading propaganda which was critical for maintaining geopolitical influence and state-controlled media was used as a tool for promoting war efforts in citizens.

In the 1990s, with the advent of digital media, conflict reporting increased. Media coverages were interpreted by a wider audience and uncensored footage of war became easily accessible on different platforms. The easy accessibility to various media sources led to drastic shifts in public opinions which could not be monitored as efficiently. Anti-war sentiments were created amongst the public and international forums including the United Nations working towards calling for international cooperation in preventing further wars.

In the mid-2000s, media coverage of the U.S. government's involvement in Iraq pressured the U.S. government to withdraw troops from Iraq. It highlighted how public sentiment turned against the war after increasing reporting on the impact on civilians, rising instability and rising financial costs.

Conflicts such as the Rwandan Genocide (1994), Bosnian Conflict (1995), Iraq War (2003), and Russia-Ukraine Conflict (2023) are examples of how media will always be an integral part of our knowledge about these conflicts. They can shape the course of conflicts like in the case of the

Rwandan genocide or encourage international interventions like in the case of the Iraq War. It has the power to shape public opinion, political actions and societal outcomes.

STAKEHOLDERS

When examining the role of media in conflict zones, it is essential to consider the various stakeholders who actively influence the media sources. These stakeholders, ranging from governments and state actors to independent journalists and non-state groups—use the media to either control narratives, foster peace, or at times, escalate tensions. Each group has unique interests and motivations and thus understanding the distinct roles and responsibilities of these stakeholders helps to provide a clearer picture of how media impacts the dynamics of conflict and the broader outcomes of peace or war.

Media as a Catalyst for Violence

Media, often regarded as the mouthpiece of society, holds immense power in shaping perceptions and reflecting realities. However, it can also become a trigger for violence when it amplifies biased opinions, hate speech, or extremist ideologies. In conflict zones, where tensions are already heightened, media channels can escalate hostility. When manipulated for these purposes, the media can turn information into a weapon that fuels chaos and destruction.

Government

Authoritarian regimes and other state actors often wield media as a powerful tool to manipulate public opinion and heighten divisions within society. Through state-

controlled media, governments can polarise opposing groups by promoting ethnic nationalism to intensify tensions. In Yugoslavia, the government used media to deepen ethnic divisions, ultimately fueling widespread violence. Another tactic is censorship, where the state restricts media freedom by allowing only its narrative to be presented while silencing alternative voices. Governments also use media depictions to justify military interventions, framing them as essential for national security. In extreme cases, state-controlled media channels are used to incite direct violence. A chilling example is Radio Mille Collines in Rwanda, whose hate-filled broadcasts triggered the 1994 genocide, an incident explored in greater detail later in this guide. During the Bosnian War (1992), state-controlled media led to 1000000 deaths and displacement for over 2 million as a part of the ethnic cleansing campaign.¹⁰

Independent Journalists and Civil Society groups

Local media and independent journalists face challenges for maintaining credibility which leads to them acting as a source of misinformation. Local media outlets can escalate existing tensions far quicker than international media outlets due to their accessibility and relatability amongst localities. In conflict zones, local media is often seen as reporting biased or one-sided views, as witnessed during the Syrian Civil War and Egypt's Arab Spring, where media outlets fueled political divides. Local media outlets are known to glorify rebels and militants sometimes even serving as recruitment tools for insurgent groups.

¹⁰the rwandan genocide. (n.d.). <https://www.unhcr.org/sites/default/files/legacy-pdf/3ebf9bb60.pdf>

Non-State Actors

Extremist groups and other non-state actors often leverage the media to spread propaganda and recruit marginalised individuals globally. These groups use local media and online platforms to broadcast hate speech, incite violence, and terrorise populations. Additionally, they exploit the media to gain international sympathy or create international lobbies for their support. Video bits released by groups like Al-Qaeda or ISIS have been used to terrorise populations and create panic. Non-state actors can include political factions aiming to manipulate public opinion or influence political outcomes, often by inciting violence to destabilise governments and gain power. As of 2015, approximately 30,000 fighters from at least 85 countries had joined the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) largely through media and propaganda campaigns.¹¹

Media as a Catalyst for Peace

Government

As a major source for influencing public opinion, the media can serve the government to publicise peace settlements and hasten the peace process in conflict zones. It is essential for broadcasting national unity programs post-conflict, as seen in South Africa, where the government aired the Truth and Reconciliation Commission hearings to promote national healing after apartheid. Governments can also utilise the media to educate citizens about electoral processes and humanitarian support, encouraging broader participation in nation-building. Media

campaigns can further help counter extremist messaging, facilitating de-radicalization and long-term societal peace. Additionally, post-conflict governments can be held accountable through a free press, ensuring transparency and improved governance for sustainable peace. The South African Truth and Reconciliation Commission received over 22,000 victim testimonies, many of which were broadcast to encourage national healing.¹²

Independent Journalists and Civil Society groups

At the grassroots of any conflict are the independent journalists and citizens alike. Local reporters often bring in key insights from the ground to promote reconciliation in a much more effective manner. Civil society members highlight the root causes of conflict and social issues to bring about better media discussions. Local journalists become central to accessing areas of conflict zones that might have been stopped for entry and voice the concerns of marginalised groups. It is also usually independent and local journalists which hold state-controlled media accountable and expose various atrocities. Through the media, non-violent resistance can be organised and amplified by civil society groups.

Non-state actors

Non-governmental organisations act as key non-state players in promoting peace. They collaborate with local media to create culturally sensitive programs, as seen in countries like Sudan and Liberia, where organisations like

¹¹Where are Isis's foreign fighters coming from? NBER. (n.d.). <https://www.nber.org/digest/jun16/where-are-isiss-foreign-fighters-coming>

¹²Truth and reconciliation commission of south africa report. (n.d.-b). <https://www.nelsonmandela.org/uploads/files/TRC-Report-1998.pdf>

Search for Common Ground¹³ work through radio and television to foster dialogue. NGOs also play a significant role in educating citizens on peace processes and providing neutral platforms for warring factions to communicate. In addition, NGOs often focus on mental health and community rebuilding by working directly with marginalised groups that may be overlooked in broader media coverage. They go the extra mile to work on the ground with citizens who might not be focused as much through broadcasting programs.

EFFECTS

Local Effects

Ethnic hatred and violence are often exaggerated by local media outlets that lack resources or independence, resulting in the spread of false information and rumours. These factors deepen distrust and fuel divisions among ethnic, religious, and political groups. A cycle of violence is created on the local level when the glorification of militants causes further means of continuing violence.

However, local media also plays a critical role in disseminating essential information during conflicts. For example, initiatives like the Darfur Lifeline¹⁴ provided displaced populations with crucial updates on accessing healthcare services. In addition to offering a platform for discussions, local media can educate citizens on civic responsibilities and promote community resilience in times of crisis.

National Effects

Authoritarian regimes often use the media as a tool for state propaganda, suppressing opposition and controlling the narrative. This limits the ability of citizens to unite for peaceful resolutions, as alternative viewpoints are silenced. In such cases, the media can either reinforce or undermine national identity, depending on how it is manipulated.

Conversely, in democratic contexts or post-conflict scenarios, the media can play a positive role by supporting democratic processes and humanitarian campaigns. The use of national media to promote peace settlements can build psychological confidence in citizens, helping them accept new governance structures.

A term coined in the 1990s as the CNN effect¹⁵ is a phenomenon where real-time media coverage influences public opinion, accelerates responses and also influences government policies into performing actions in real-time.



The CNN Effect: Policymaking in Changing Mediascapes

Source: Australian Institute of International Affairs

In Zimbabwe, state-controlled media is used as an instrument of government control,

¹³What we do. Search for Common Ground. (2023, November 14). <https://www.sfcg.org/what-we-do/>

¹⁴A decade of transforming lives through media - gov.uk. (n.d.). https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/57a08b5440f0b64974000ac2/trust_at_10_web.pdf

¹⁵Tomja, A. (n.d.). *The "Cnn effect" and its influence on US foreign policy decision-making*. Interdisciplinary Journal of Research and Development. <https://www.journal-uamd.org/index.php/IJRD/article/view/215>

continuously vilifying opposition figures as foreign puppets. This type of media manipulation contributes to an atmosphere of fear and violent intimidation, while independent media—limited in scope—struggles to reach broader audiences.

International Effects

Media plays a huge role in shaping international narratives about a country and can affect their socio-economic existence based on perceptions of the international community. Shallow reporting for the sake of sensationalism can distract the community from the root cause and underlying causes. Further, biased or incomplete views on a conflict that are suited to national beliefs can cause a lack of a holistic approach towards the conflict. Western media coverage has often been criticised for giving a one-sided narrative on conflicts in the Middle East depending on their foreign policy. Extremist groups also use the media to spread fear globally, amplifying their reach beyond borders.

On the positive side, the media can be a powerful tool for mobilising international humanitarian aid. Conflicts that receive substantial media attention are more likely to garner global support and intervention. Exposing human rights violations through media outlets leads to global calls for action, pressuring governments and international organisations to intervene. Additionally, media coverage of global peace discussions can inspire positive change, helping to build consensus for peacebuilding efforts across the international community.

When the UK-based Independent Television News (ITN) reported the existence of the Serb

detention camps at Omarska and Trnopolje it helped build support for UN Resolution 770, which allowed for “all necessary measures” in the delivery of humanitarian aid.

PAST LAWS AND MECHANISMS

The responsibilities of all the stakeholders are guided by an evolving set of international laws, mechanisms, and ethical frameworks that work towards preventing the misuse of media to incite violence.

International Humanitarian Law

International Humanitarian Law¹⁶ encompasses the Geneva Conventions and their additional protocols, governing the protection of individuals during wartime. Article 79 of Additional Protocol I emphasises the protection of journalists in conflict zones, granting them the same protections as civilians. This article prohibits violence against journalists, including murder, cruel treatment, and hostage-taking. This framework provides a legal basis for protecting the rights of media personnel, ensuring that they can report on conflicts without fear of attack.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights¹⁷, adopted in 1948, sets out fundamental rights and freedoms to which all people are entitled. Article 19 is particularly relevant to the role of media, as it guarantees freedom of expression, including the right to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas through any media. This article forms the backbone of media rights in conflict zones, as it supports the free flow of information, which is essential for transparency, accountability, and the protection of human rights.

¹⁶International humanitarian law. (n.d.). https://www.icrc.org/en/download/file/40569/en_-_handbook_humanitarian_law_-_web.pdf

¹⁷United Nations. (n.d.). *Universal declaration of human rights*. United Nations. <https://www.un.org/en/about-us/universal-declaration-of-human-rights>

The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights

The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights¹⁸, adopted in 1966, is another key international treaty that protects civil and political rights, including the freedom of expression outlined in Article 19. However, Article 20 of the ICCPR takes this protection a step further by explicitly prohibiting the spread of propaganda for war and any advocacy of hatred that constitutes incitement to violence. This provision highlights the dual role of media—while it can promote freedom of expression, it can also be a tool for spreading hate speech and inciting conflict if misused.

The International Federation of Journalists

The International Federation of Journalists (IFJ)¹⁹ has established a Code of Ethics that serves as a moral guide for journalists worldwide. This code includes principles such as truthfulness, accuracy, and the responsibility to avoid harm through reporting. The Code of Ethics ensures that journalists maintain high standards of professionalism and integrity, particularly in conflict zones where misinformation or biased reporting can escalate violence.



The Federation of Asia-Pacific Journalists
Source: National Union of Journalists of the Philippines

The International Criminal Court

The International Criminal Court (ICC)²⁰, established in 2002, prosecutes individuals responsible for genocide, crimes against humanity, and war crimes. Under Articles 25, 7, and 8 of the Rome Statute, individuals—including media professionals—who facilitate or incite these crimes can be prosecuted. For instance, if media outlets or journalists knowingly incite genocide or assist in war crimes through their reporting, they can be held accountable under international law.

International Programme for the Development of Communication

UNESCO's International Programme for the Development of Communication (IPDC)²¹ emphasises the importance of regulatory measures to ensure the safety of journalists in conflict zones. The IPDC promotes the

¹⁸ International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights | Ohchr. (n.d.). <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights>

¹⁹ Global charter of ethics for journalists. IFJ. (n.d.). <https://www.ifj.org/who/rules-and-policy/global-charter-of-ethics-for-journalists#:~:text=The%20journalist%20shall%20report%20only,persons%20publish%20in%20social%20media.>

²⁰ International Criminal Court. (n.d.). <https://www.icc-cpi.int/>

²¹ Unesco, & (Ukraine), H. R. P. (1970, January 1). *International Programme for the development of Communication*. UNESCO.org. <https://www.unesco.org/en/international-programme-development-communication>

dissemination of accurate information while also advocating for the protection of reporters who are often at risk in conflict areas.

The program's focus on media development in post-conflict regions highlights the need for journalism that supports peacebuilding and democratic processes. UNESCO's initiatives have helped create a safer environment for journalists by advocating for regulatory protections and training on how to navigate complex conflict situations responsibly.

EU Audiovisual Media Services Directive

The EU Audiovisual Media Services Directive (AVMSD)²² sets out a regulatory framework for audiovisual media across Europe. It aims to protect fundamental freedoms while ensuring that the media does not incite violence or spread hate speech, particularly during conflicts. The AVMSD is a significant mechanism for ensuring that media outlets in Europe adhere to standards that promote responsible journalism and avoid contributing to societal unrest.

CASE STUDY

Rwanda

One of the most horrific genocides of the 20th century was recorded in 1994 when more than 800,000 Tutsi were slaughtered in Rwanda by agitated militias and civilians. Rising ethnic tensions were results of misinformation spread by media outlets and by one in particular which was Radio Television Libre des Mille Collines.

In April 1993, the Hutu extremists established their own radio station, Radio Télévision Libre des Mille Collines (RTLM). Anti-Tutsi propaganda also saturated the local newspapers. As the

violence escalated, those who opposed the propaganda were targeted and killed, and soon the Hutu extremists were in control of all national media. RTLM became the extremists' chief means of communication, and orders to kill were simply broadcast to the nation.

The mass slaughter began with the death of the Rwandan president, Juvenal Habyarimana, who was shot down in a plane on 6 April 1994. Immediately afterwards, opposition leaders were murdered and their headquarters in Kigali, Rwanda's capital, were attacked by extremist elements within the military that took control upon President Habyarimana's death. This was followed by the mobilisation of about 30,000 Hutu extremists, the Interahamwe, who swept through the country with the military and slaughtered all Tutsis and moderate Hutus they could find.

RTLM gave specific instructions and named places to attack Tutsis which motivated the perpetrators of violence to coordinate attacks and amplify the scale of the genocide. The false propaganda shared by the media channel created fear amongst Hutus and blinded them into mobilising against the Tutsis who were supposedly planning to overthrow the Hutu government which turned out to be false information. Existing peace mechanisms and efforts like UNAMIR were overthrown by the continual interference of media outlets in the portrayal of the Tutsi groups as aggressors and terrorists.

²²Audiovisual and media services. Shaping Europe's digital future. (n.d.). <https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/audiovisual-and-media-services>



Deceptive Discourse of Genocide in Rwanda
Source: Human Rights Watch

CONCLUSION

The power of the media is undeniably crucial in times of conflict in any part of the world. In times of limited access and collapsing governance

instruments, the media becomes the backbone of ensuring accessible information for the international community and the victims of the conflict. The role of media can be judged as a catalyst for peace as well as violence depending upon the quality and intent of information propagated by media outlets. It is the rightful duty of the journalists and reporters to ensure they abide by journalistic standards and other actors must ensure they do not misuse media to incite violence and conflict. Initiatives for improving media coordination will amplify the greater good that media can contribute in these trying times of conflicts and chaos.